

Meaning of Ibadah

Root Word of Ibadah: The word ‘Ibadah is an Arabic word, which came from its root word: ‘ABD’ (ع ب د), so we are slaves/ ‘Ibad (عباد) of Allah (SWT), and we are created for performing ‘Ibadah (عبادة).

Literal Meaning of Ibadah: Generally, ‘Ibadah means: Slave, full-time servant or to serve. All the actions of a slave to make his master pleased is ‘Ibadah, so we are ABD of Allah (SWT) and all our actions for the sake of Allah’s (SWT) pleasure are considered as ‘Ibadah.

From different scholars, we get the meaning of Ibadah in the Arabic language as: obedience, submission, humility, servility, worship and adoration. Obedience with lowering one’s self and the slave is called ‘Abd’ due to his submission and obedience.

Terminological Meaning of Ibadah: Imam Ibn Taymiah said: “The ‘Ibadah is a noun (word) that includes everything that Allah (SWT) loves and accepts from sayings and the physical acts; the hidden (acts by heart) and the openly (acts by limbs).

All obedience, noble and beneficial deeds (acts) which Allah (SWT) ordered us to do or not to do either related to our life on earth or on the Day of Judgment, and which are selected by and not against Shariah’, and which are practiced to get the satisfaction of Allah (SWT) are called ‘Ibadah. Allah (SWT) said: “Say: Truly, my prayer and my service of sacrifice, my life and my death, are (all) for Allah (SWT), the Cherisher of the Worlds”, [Surah Anam/ 6: 162].

Obedience with submission and lowering one’s self, and accepting being led by Allah (SWT), in everything that He has ordered and everything that He has forbidden is Ibadah.

Every action is considered as a form of ‘Ibadah provided that it should be with good intention and accordance with the Holy Qur’an and the Sunnah.

Therefore, examples of Ibadah are:

The acts by heart including all articles related to pillars of Iman.

The acts by limbs including the prayer, zakah, fasting, hajj, truthfulness, loyalty,

kindness to parents, having good accord with relatives, keeping promises, ordering what is good and forbidding from what is evil, fighting against the kuffar and the hypocrites, kindness to the neighbor, to the orphan, to the poor, to the wayfarer, to the animals, supplication, remembering Allah (SWT), reciting the Holy Qur'an, and all things of this nature are from 'Ibadah.

Clear Concept of Ibadah: 'Ibadah in Islam is understood in comprehensive meaning, so the concept of 'Ibadah in Islam means: Which works and activities are included in the word 'Ibadah. If we think deeply then we can understand that all our activities may be included in the term of 'Ibadah, if we follow the rules of Islam and fulfill all conditions of 'Ibadah; because the main aim of our creation is none but only to serve (by fixed way) Allah (SWT), and this is 'Ibadah. Allah (SWT) said in the Holy Qur'an: "I created the Jinn and mankind only that they might worship (perform 'Ibadah to) Me" [Surah Jariath/51:56]

Misunderstanding of Ibadah: The concept of 'Ibadah by many people is commonly taken to mean performing ritualistic acts such as Prayers, Fasting, Charity, Hajj etc. This limited understanding of 'Ibadah is only one aspect of the meaning of 'Ibadah in Islam; the real definition of 'Ibadah in Islam is a comprehensive definition that includes almost every aspect of human life and individual's activities.

Meaning of Ibadah: As discussed earlier, we can say that 'Ibadah is all-inclusive that one says or does for the pleasure of Allah (SWT). This, of course, includes rituals as well as beliefs, social activities, and personal contributions to the welfare of fellow human beings.

Clear concept of Ibadah in Islam: Islam looks at the individual as a whole. He is required to submit himself completely to Allah (SWT), as the Qur'an instructed to the Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) to do.

Nature of Ibadah: The natural result of this submission is that all our activities should comply with the instructions of the one to whom we are submitting. Islam, being a **way of life**, requires that its followers model their life according to its teachings in every aspect, religious or otherwise. Allah (SWT) said: "O you who believe! Enter perfectly into Islam and follow not the footsteps of Shaitan..." [Surah Al-Baqarah/2:208].

Ibadah is to perform all good deeds: Islam does not think much of mere rituals when they are performed mechanically and have no influence on one's inner life. The Qur'an addresses the concept of righteousness in the following verse: "It is not righteousness that you turn your faces toward the East or the West, but righteous is he who believes in Allah (SWT) and the Last Day and the Angels and the Book and the Prophets, and gives his beloved money to his relatives and the orphans and the needy and for the ransoming of captives, and who observes Prayer and pays the poor-due; and those who fulfill their promises when they have made one, and the patient in poverty and affliction and the steadfast in time of war; it is those who have proved truthful and it is those who are the Allah (SWT) (Lord)-fearer" [2: 177].

The concept of Ibadah in Islam is a comprehensive concept: It is clear that the concept of 'Ibadah in Islam is a comprehensive concept that includes all the positive activities of the individual. This, of course, is in agreement with the all-inclusive nature of Islam as a **way of life**. It regulates human life on all levels: **individual, social, economic, political and spiritual**. That is why Islam provides guidance to the smallest details of our life on all these levels. Thus following these details is following Islamic instructions in that specific area. It is a very encouraging element when one realizes that **all his activities are considered by Allah (SWT) as acts of 'Ibadah**. This should lead the individual to seek Allah (SWT)'s pleasure in his actions and always try to do them in the best possible manner whether he is watched by his superiors or he is alone. There is always the permanent supervisor, who knows everything, namely, Allah (SWT).

Thus, Ibadah also includes decent work, seeking knowledge, social courtesy and cooperation, performing in our duties, showing kindness, good relation between husband and wife, etc.